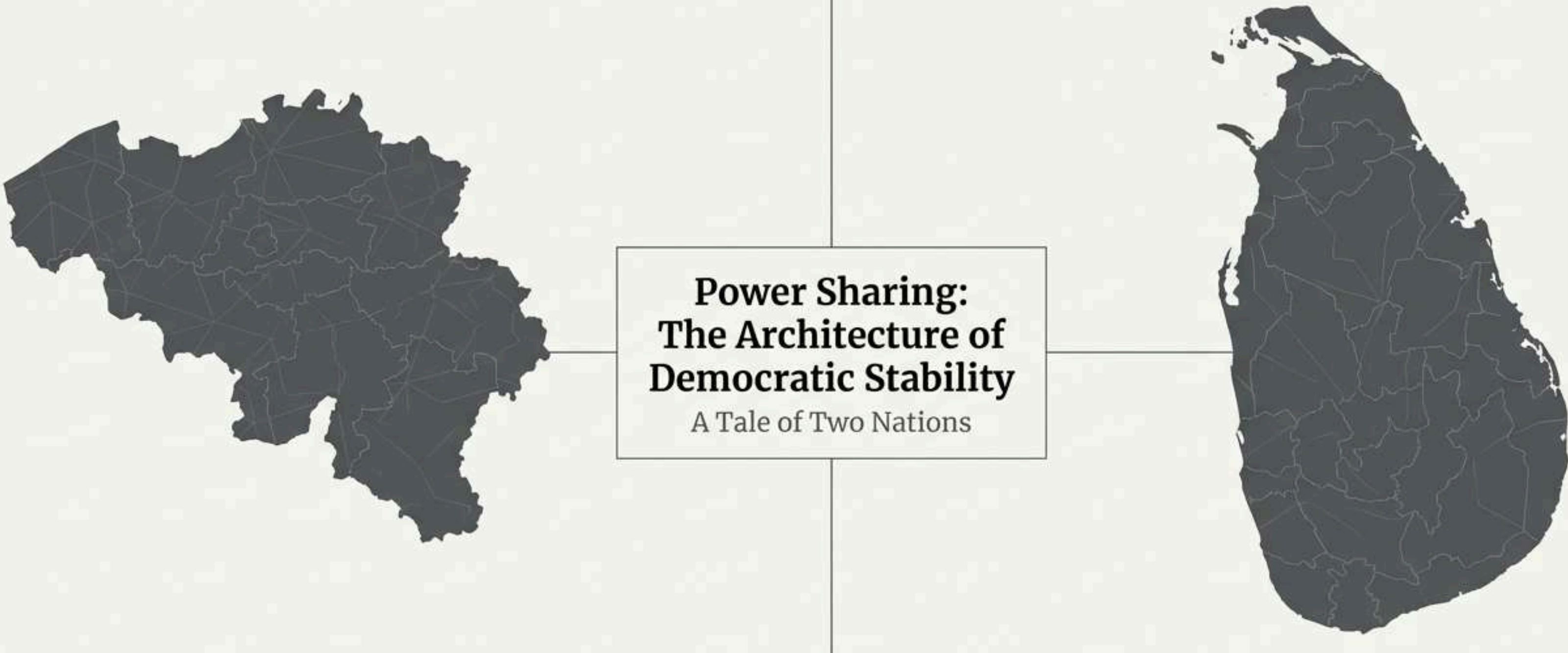


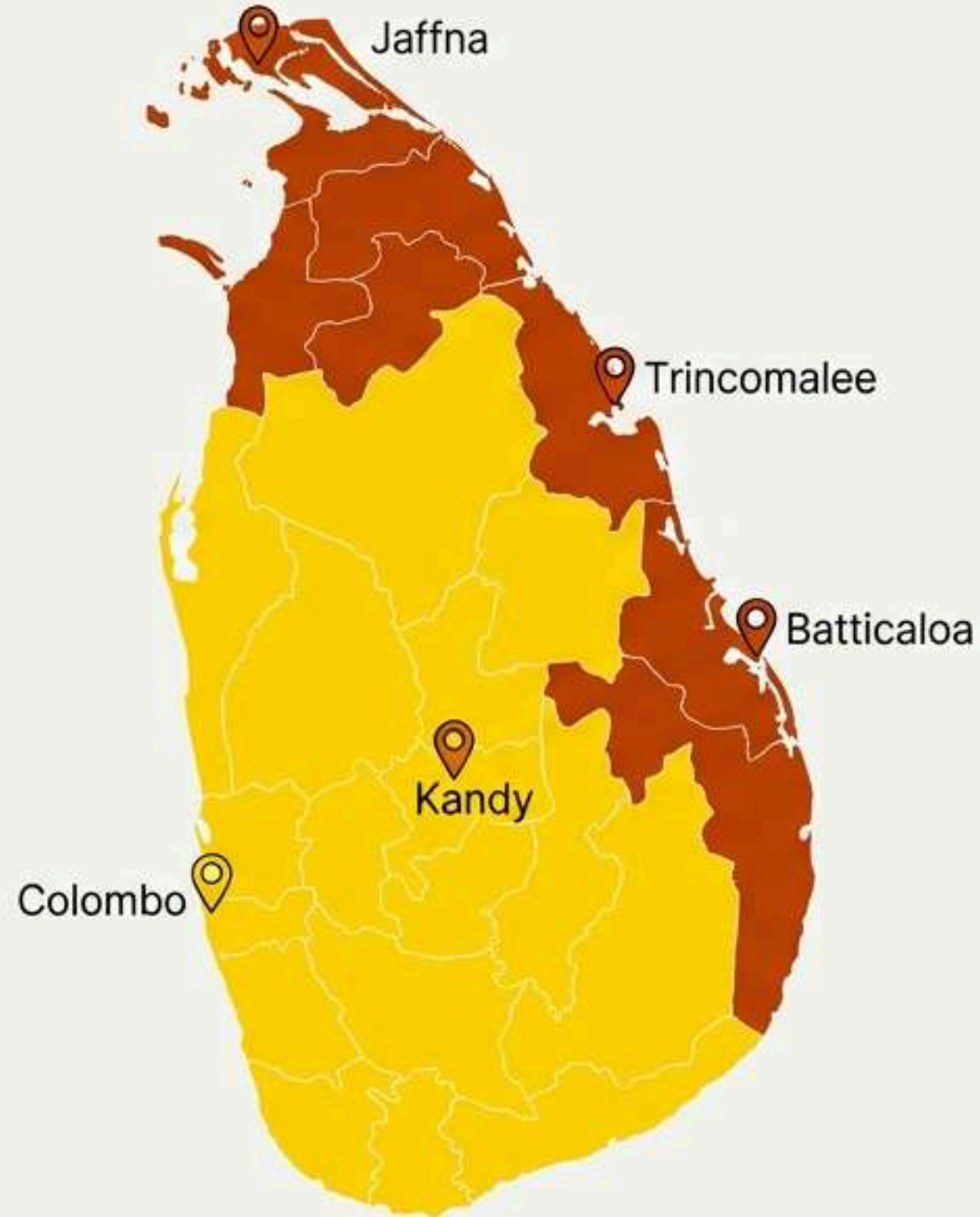


Power Sharing: The Architecture of Democratic Stability

A Tale of Two Nations

In a democracy, power does not rest with any one organ. Intelligent sharing among the legislature, executive, and judiciary is critical to the design. This presentation compares the divergent paths of Belgium and Sri Lanka.

The Demographic Fault Lines of Sri Lanka



Population: ~20 Million (Comparable to Haryana)



Sinhala-speakers (74%)

The overwhelming majority.

Tamil-speakers (18%)

- Sri Lankan Tamils (13%): Natives, concentrated in the North and East.
- Indian Tamils (5%): Colonial-era plantation workers.

The Policy of Majoritarianism (1956)



Majoritarianism: A belief that the majority community should be able to rule a country in whichever way it wants, by disregarding the wishes and needs of the minority.



Sinhala recognized as the only official language.



Preferential policies favoured **Sinhala** applicants for university and government jobs.



State constitutional obligation to protect and foster **Buddhism**.

From Alienation to Civil War



1956 - Alienation

Tamils felt policies denied equal rights and discriminated in jobs.

1960s-70s - Struggles

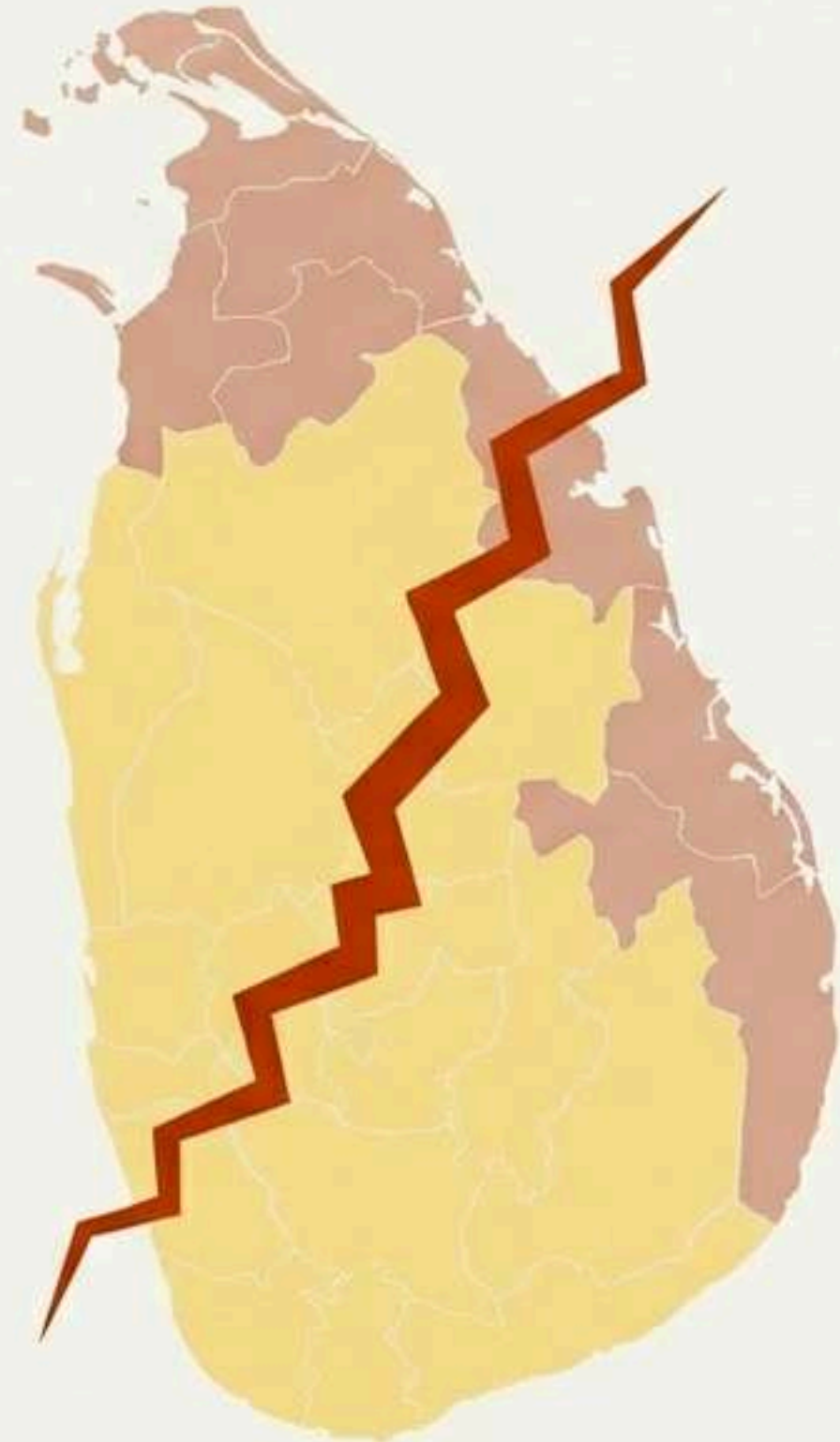
Launch of parties demanding Tamil as an official language and regional autonomy.

1980s - Radicalisation

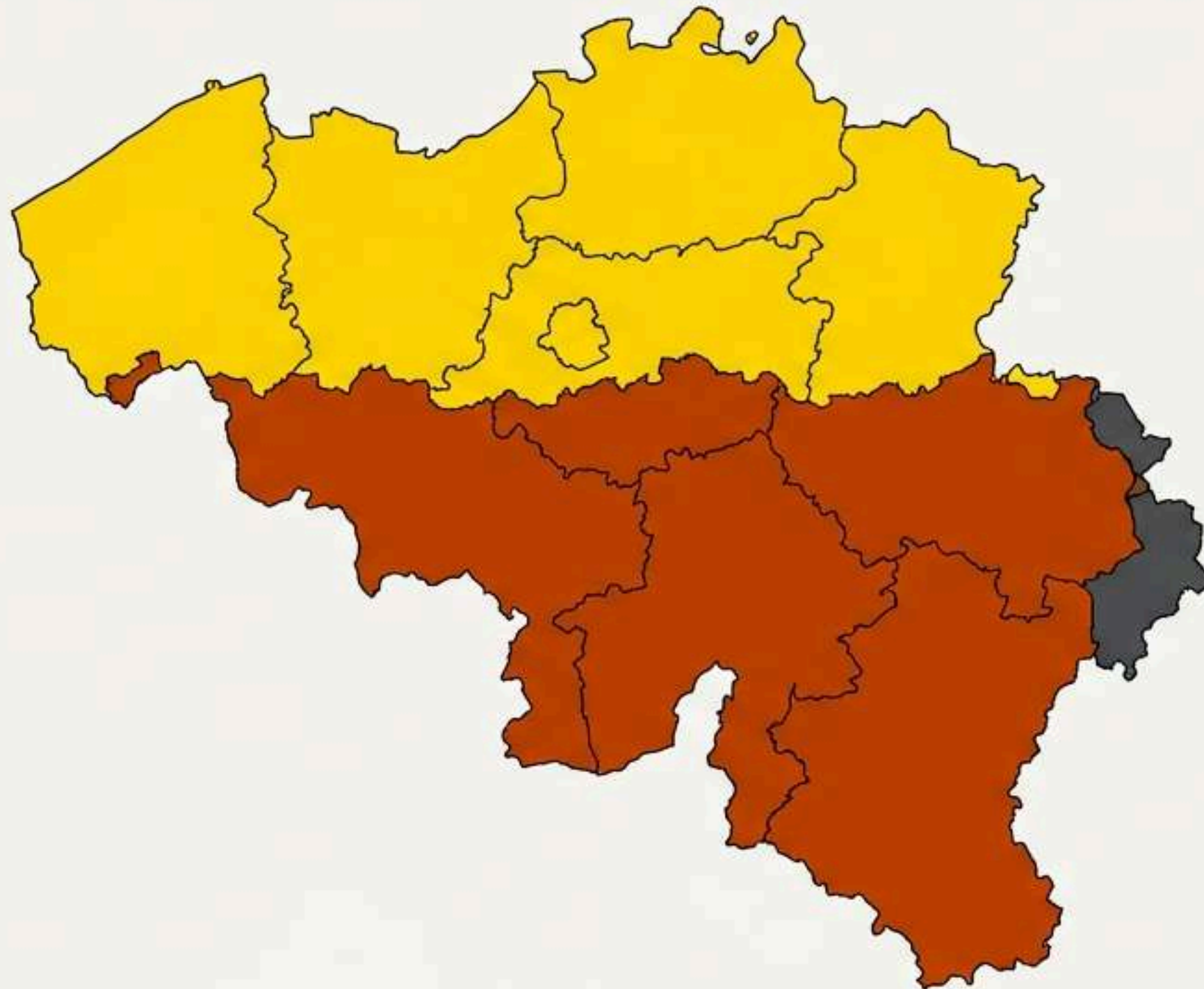
Demand shifted to an independent state: Tamil Eelam.

1983-2009 - Civil War

Widespread conflict. Thousands killed. Economic and social setback.



The Belgian Puzzle



Data Breakdown:



Flemish Region (North):
59% Population - Speaks Dutch



Wallonia Region (South):
40% Population - Speaks French

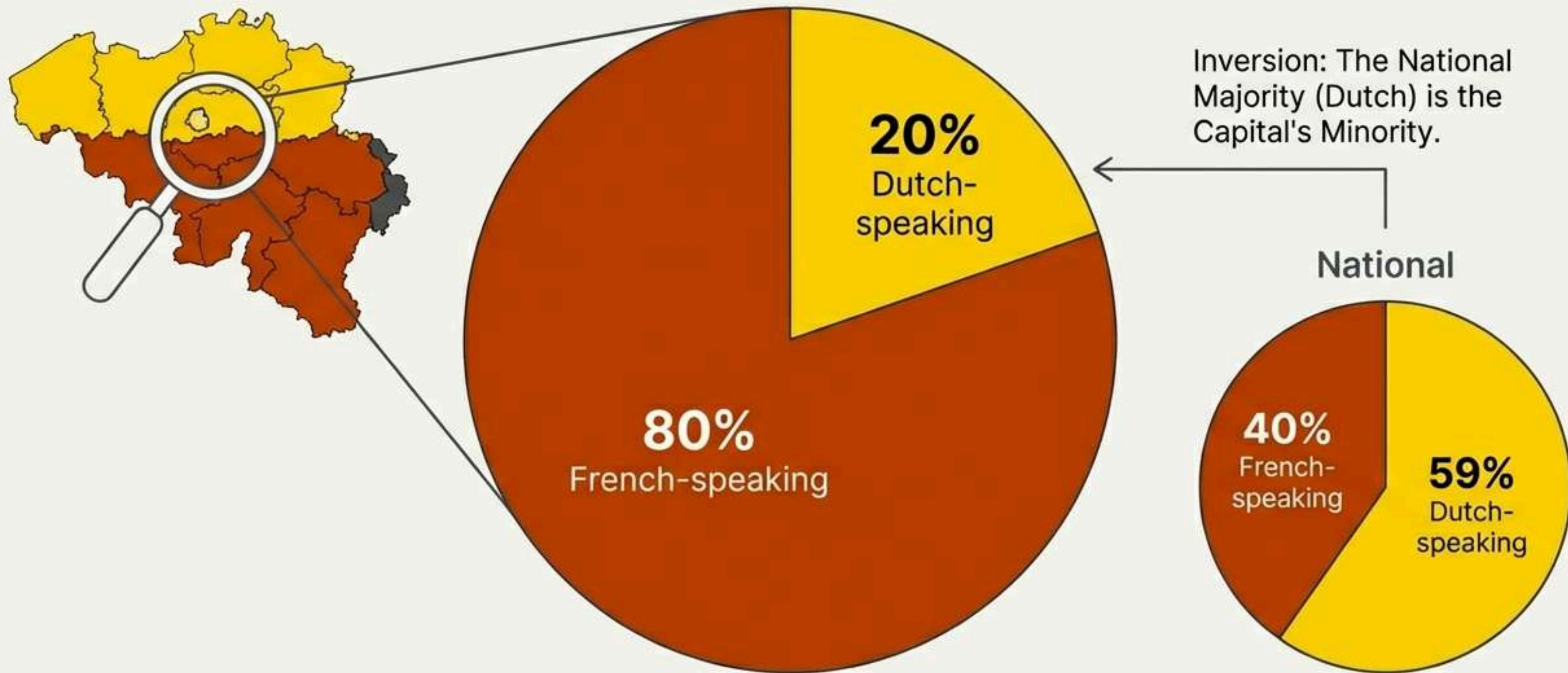


German-speaking: 1%



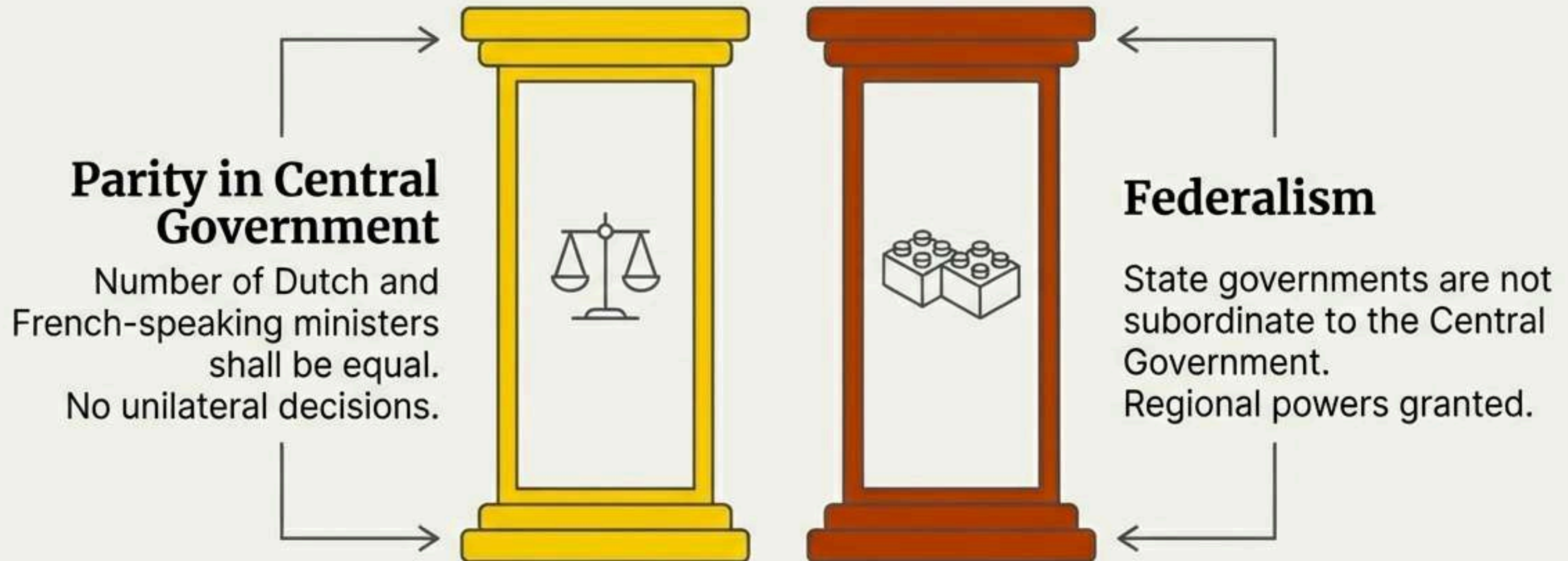
Context: The minority French-speaking community was historically richer and more powerful, creating resentment among the Dutch-speaking majority.

The Brussels Paradox



The Path of Accommodation (1970–1993)

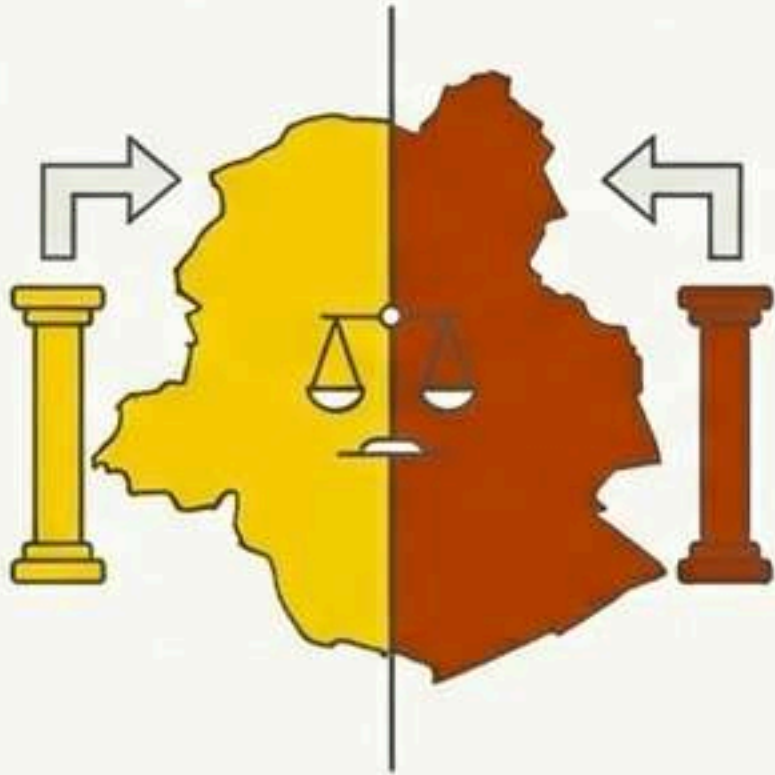
Four Constitutional Amendments



Result: A complex but effective arrangement enabling coexistence.

Innovative Governance Structures

Brussels Capital Region



Separate government with equal representation (50-50).

The French accepted this because the Dutch accepted parity at the National level.

The Community Government



A unique third tier elected by language groups (Dutch, French, German) regardless of location.



Power over Culture



Power over Education



Power over Language

Outcome: Brussels is now the headquarters of the European Union.

Two Democracies, Two Opposite Outcomes

The Path of Accommodation



Realised unity is possible only by respecting the feelings of different communities.

Sustainable Unity

The Path of Majoritarianism



Majority dominance forces unity and refuses to share power.

Undermines Unity

Why is Power Sharing Desirable?



Prudential Reasons

Practical Outcomes

- Reduces the possibility of conflict between social groups.
- Ensures the stability of political order.
- Preventing majority tyranny preserves national unity in the long run.

Moral Reasons

Democratic Values



- Power sharing is the very spirit of democracy.
- People have a legitimate right to be consulted.
- Legitimate government involves sharing power with those affected by it.

Horizontal Distribution of Power

A System of Checks and Balances



Power is shared among organs at the same level. No organ exercises unlimited power; each checks the others.

Vertical Distribution of Power

Federalism



Constitutional division of power ensures lower levels are not dependent on the central level.

Sharing Power Among Groups and Parties

Social Groups



Community Government (Belgium) & Reserved Constituencies.

Parties & Pressure Groups



Coalition Government: Direct power sharing when no single party wins a majority.

Influence: Traders, workers, and farmers influence decision-making.

The Evolution of Political Power



The Old Notion

Sharing power = Weakening the country.



The Democratic Reality

People rule themselves through institutions of self-government.



In a modern democratic country, political power must be distributed among citizens to ensure stability, unity, and legitimacy.